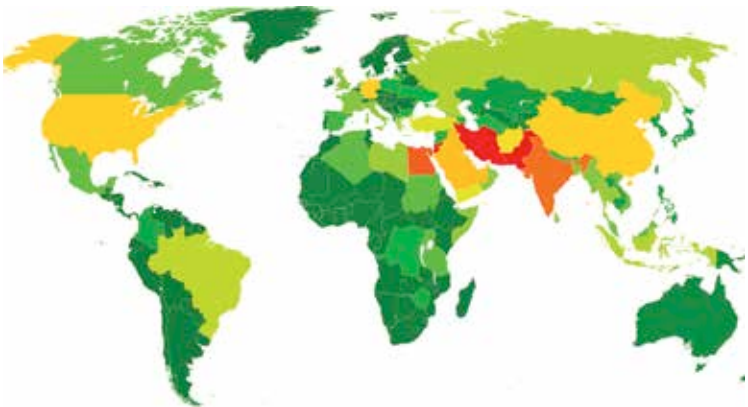


Data measures the user's behaviour in a quantitative manner. Simple things such as: What did they do? What link did they click on? How many times did they repeat a certain action? How long did it take from action A to B? And so on...

There's a very low margin of error since data is measured and recorded by a computer. The collected data is quantitative user behaviour. It consists of easily measurable and well defined criteria such as number of clicks, time taken for an action, browser used, etc. Also, data from millions of people can be measured at the same time, using analytics software. This greatly reduces selection biases in a systematic manner. The more people measured, the more useful and unbiased is the data!

Most importantly, data never lies. Users cannot influence data, though they compose it. However, it's us erroneous human designers who interpret said data – and that's where most mistakes happen, if any. Further, data comes to us in the form of numbers, so we tend to treat it as just that. Not much different from using a chainsaw to snip off some cellotape.

The numbers represent the behaviours of thousands (or however many measured) of complex human beings. Do not fool yourself into examining the *causes* for the numbers being what they're, thinking you can comprehend it to mean something. Rather, look towards the *effect* on the numbers, since that's the substance of the data. Use that to guide your decisions. As a rule of thumb, the more important the decision, the more data you should collect!



Heatmap of terrorist informants across the globe